

Psalms 12

When Lying Lips Prevail

Help, Lord; for the godly man ceaseth

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Help, LORD; for the godly man ceaseth; for the faithful fail from among the children of men.*
- 2 *They speak vanity every one with his neighbour: with flattering lips and with a double heart do they speak.*
- 3 *The LORD shall cut off all flattering lips, and the tongue that speaketh proud things:*
- 4 *Who have said, With our tongue will we prevail; our lips are our own: who is lord over us?*
- 5 *For the oppression of the poor, for the sighing of the needy, now will I arise, saith the LORD; I will set him in safety from him that puffeth at him.*
- 6 *The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times.*
- 7 *Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever.*
- 8 *The wicked walk on every side, when the vilest men are exalted.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 12 laments a culture of flattery and deceit in which the godly seem to be vanishing and the vulnerable are preyed upon by proud speech. Attributed to David and set “upon Sheminith” in the superscription, it moves from social complaint to a pure divine promise and back to a sober reminder that the wicked still walk freely for now. Henry highlights the contrast between the corrosive “double heart” of flatterers and the flawless purity of God’s own words.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

An urgent cry: help, for the godly and faithful seem to have vanished. What remains is vanity-speech, flattering lips, and a “double heart”—one thing said, another intended. The complaint names a social sickness: truth-telling itself is endangered.

Verse 3-4

David asks the Lord to cut off flattering lips and the boastful tongue of those who say, “With our tongue will we prevail... who is lord over us?” Self-sufficient speech that denies any accountability above itself is exposed as the real target of judgment.

Verse 5-6

God answers directly: because of the oppression of the poor and the sighing of the needy, “I will arise... I will set him in safety.” In contrast to corrupt human words, “the words of the Lord are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace... purified seven times.” Divine speech is the reliable counterpart to unreliable human speech.

Verse 7-8

Assurance that the Lord will keep and preserve His people “from this generation forever”—even while, realistically, “the wicked walk on every side, when the vilest men are exalted.” Faith holds both truths: promised preservation and present, unresolved wickedness.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

In a culture of flattery, spin, and double talk, God notices the oppression behind smooth words, promises to arise for the poor, and offers His own pure, tested word as the trustworthy alternative to human speech that cannot be trusted.

Application for life today.

Audit your own speech for the “double heart” this psalm names—saying one thing while meaning or planning another. When surrounded by flattery, spin, or cynical self-sufficiency (“who is lord over us?”), let God’s tried and purified words, not the loudest voices, set your standard for truth. And when the vilest seem exalted, hold onto verse 5: God has not stopped watching the sighing of the needy.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where have you seen flattery or a “double heart” damage trust in your relationships or community?

2. How does knowing God’s words are “purified seven times” shape which voices you let shape your convictions?

3. Who around you is sighing under oppression right now, and how might God be calling you to “arise” for them?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).